

STRAWBERRY DREAM DRESS

PREEMIE TO 2 MONTHS

A sleeveless, top-down baby dress with a leaf yoke, knitted-in seeds and a soft flared skirt. Graded in five sizes, from the very smallest premature baby up to two months.

32

preemie, approx. 1.0-1.5 kg

38

preemie, approx. 1.5-2.5 kg

44

small newborn, approx. 2.5-3.2 kg

50

newborn, approx. 3.2-4.2 kg

56

approx. 1-2 months

By Renate Dahl

Little Montessori Explorers

lmexplorers.com



Read the whole pattern before you start, and knit a gauge swatch. Mark your own size in the tables so you do not have to search as you go. **Test knit version 1.0**

BEFORE YOU START

The dress is knitted top-down with a small buttoned opening at the back neck. The neck is cast on in green and divided into 8 sections, and the increases shape the round yoke. After the leaf panel the armhole stitches are set aside, the body is worked in the round down to the waist, and there it is increased out into a light, full skirt.

WHAT YOU WILL LEARN

- knitting a sleeveless yoke from the top down
- working leaf tips and seeds in two colours
- increasing evenly from waist into a skirt
- working a picot edge and armhole edgings

DIFFICULTY

Easy to slightly experienced. You should be able to knit in the round, increase, decrease and carry two colours in the same round.

SIZES AND FINISHED MEASUREMENTS

The pattern is graded in five sizes. Choose by the baby's chest measurement, not by age: premature babies grow at their own pace, and a couple of weeks makes a big difference. Between two sizes, take the larger one, since a garment that is slightly big lasts longer.

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THE BABY'S MEASUREMENTS

Size	Suits	Baby chest	Ease
32	preemie, approx. 1.0-1.5 kg	24 cm	4,6 cm
38	preemie, approx. 1.5-2.5 kg	27 cm	5,4 cm
44	small newborn, approx. 2.5-3.2 kg	30 cm	6,2 cm
50	newborn, approx. 3.2-4.2 kg	33 cm	7,0 cm
56	approx. 1-2 months	36 cm	7,8 cm

FINISHED MEASUREMENTS

Size	Chest	Total length	Yoke depth	Skirt from waist
32	28,6 cm	30 cm	7,5 cm	15 cm
38	32,4 cm	34 cm	8,9 cm	17 cm
44	36,2 cm	38 cm	9,6 cm	19 cm
50	40,0 cm	42 cm	11,1 cm	21 cm
56	43,8 cm	46 cm	11,8 cm	23 cm

Every number in the pattern is given in its own column per size. Find your column once, mark it, and read only that one from there on.

YARN, TOOLS AND GAUGE

YARN AND NEEDLES

DROPS Merino Extra Fine, 50 g = approx. 105 m, in strawberry pink, leaf green and a small amount of cream white. 4 mm needles, double-pointed or Magic Loop for the small rounds. The amounts below include a good margin, and are given per size.

Tools	For what
4 mm needles	double-pointed or Magic Loop for neck, armholes and skirt
1 flat button	approx. 10-12 mm, for the back neck opening
Darning needle	for weaving in ends and sewing down the picot edge
Stitch marker	to mark the beginning of the round at centre back

YARN AMOUNT

Size	Pink	Green	Cream
32	310 g	35 g	5 g
38	385 g	35 g	5 g
44	470 g	40 g	5 g
50	565 g	45 g	5 g
56	670 g	50 g	5 g

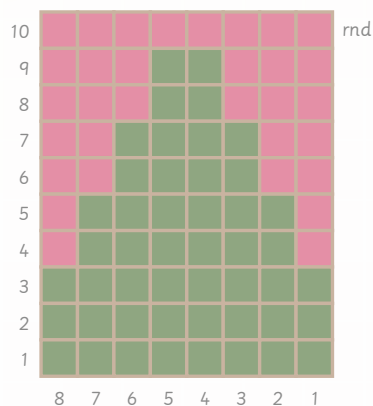
GAUGE

21 stitches and 28 rounds in stocking stitch = 10 x 10 cm on 4 mm needles. Knit your swatch in the round, not flat, and measure it after washing and drying flat. More than 21 stitches means going up a needle size, fewer means going down. The gauge decides every measurement in the pattern, and on garments this small a slight difference quickly becomes several centimetres.

LEAF AND SEED CHARTS

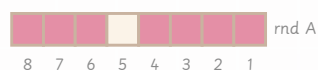
Both charts are read from the bottom up, and each round from right to left, the same way you knit. The leaf repeat is 8 stitches and is repeated all the way round the yoke. The number of repeats for your size is given further on.

LEAF, 8 STITCHES x 10 ROUNDS

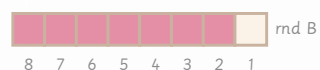


SEED, 8 STITCHES

A



B



The seeds are single cream white stitches scattered over the pink. Work round A, then 2-3 rounds in pink, then round B. Repeat as densely or as sparsely as you like.

The float behind the work is never longer than 3 stitches in either chart. That is deliberate: long loose strands on the inside are both uncomfortable against the skin and something small fingers can catch in. Keep the carried yarn loose enough that the work does not pucker.

1 • NECK AND YOKE

Cast on in green on 4 mm needles and work 4 rows of twisted rib back and forth, that is 1 twisted knit, 1 purl. On row 3 make one buttonhole 3 stitches in from the edge: knit 2 together, yarn over. Continue in stocking stitch back and forth.

THE INCREASES

Divide the stitches into 8 equal sections and place a marker between each. Increase 1 stitch in each section every other row, that is 8 stitches per increase round. When the back opening measures approx. 4 cm, cast on 2 stitches over the opening and join to work in the round. Continue the increases in the round until you have the stitch count in your column.

Size	Cast on	Sts per section	Increase rounds	After increases
32	48 sts	6	5	88 sts
38	48 sts	6	7	104 sts
44	56 sts	7	8	120 sts
50	56 sts	7	10	136 sts
56	64 sts	8	11	152 sts

The number of increase rounds differs between sizes, but the 8 sections and the 8 stitches per increase round are the same in all of them. The neck and the number of rounds create the size.

2 • THE LEAF PANEL

All the increases are done now, and the stitch count divides by 8 in every size. Work the leaf repeat from page 5 over 8 stitches, and repeat it as many times as your column says. The chart is read from the bottom up even though the garment is knitted from the top down. That is so the leaves point downwards on the finished garment.

Size	Stitches in yoke	Leaf repeats round	Yoke depth
32	88 sts	11 x	7,5 cm
38	104 sts	13 x	8,9 cm
44	120 sts	15 x	9,6 cm
50	136 sts	17 x	11,1 cm
56	152 sts	19 x	11,8 cm

AFTER THE LEAVES

Work 1 even round in pink. The yoke is now finished, and the whole garment is pink from here down apart from the seeds and the edgings.

3 • DIVIDE FOR ARMHOLES AND BODY

Read the row for your size from left to right, in the order you knit: the front, the stitches you place on hold for the first armhole, the stitches you cast on under the arm, the back, then the same armhole on the other side. The body remains on the needle.

Size	Front	Hold for armhole	Cast on	Back	Body
32	28	16	2	28	60 sts
38	32	20	2	32	68 sts
44	36	24	2	36	76 sts
50	40	28	2	40	84 sts
56	44	32	2	44	92 sts

Check the stitch count before going on. Front and back should be equal, and the two armholes should hold exactly the same number of stitches.

4 • BODY DOWN TO THE WAIST

Place the round marker at centre back and work in pink stocking stitch in the round. Scatter seeds as you go: work seed round A, then 2-3 rounds in pink, then seed round B. Repeat as densely or sparsely as you like. Work until the body measures the length in your column, measured straight down from the underarm.

Size	Body stitches	Length from underarm	Rounds, approx.
32	60 sts	7 cm	20
38	68 sts	8 cm	22
44	76 sts	9 cm	25
50	84 sts	10 cm	28
56	92 sts	11 cm	31

MARK THE WAIST

Place a marker in the round when the body is finished. That marker is the waist, and all skirt measurements are taken from it.

5 • THE SKIRT

Work *k2, M1*, repeat round. That gives the number in the first column. Work 4 rounds even, then increase evenly up to the number in the second column. The skirt is now at full width. Continue in pink stocking stitch with scattered seeds until the skirt measures the length in the last column, measured from the waist marker.

Size	*k2, M1* gives	Increase evenly to	Skirt width	Length from waist
32	90 sts	108 sts	51,4 cm	15 cm
38	102 sts	120 sts	57,1 cm	17 cm
44	114 sts	138 sts	65,7 cm	19 cm
50	126 sts	150 sts	71,4 cm	21 cm
56	138 sts	168 sts	80,0 cm	23 cm

If you want the dress longer or shorter, this is where you decide. The skirt length can be changed freely without affecting anything else in the pattern.

6 • PICOT EDGE AND ARMHOLES

THE LOWER EDGE

Work 3 rounds in pink. Then work an eyelet round: *yarn over, k2tog*, repeat round. Work 3 more rounds in pink and cast off loosely. Fold the edge to the inside along the eyelet round and sew it down with small, loose stitches. The edge should form a discreet picot, not a garter ridge.

THE ARMHOLE EDGINGS

Pick up the stitches in your column round each armhole in green: the held sleeve stitches, the stitches you cast on under the arm, and 1 stitch in each of the two corners. Work 4 rounds of twisted rib and cast off with stretch.

Size	Pick up per armhole	Rounds of twisted rib
32	20 sts	4
38	24 sts	4
44	28 sts	4
50	32 sts	4
56	36 sts	4

Sew the button on the back neck opening last, and check that the buttonhole has not stretched after washing.

FOR YOU, THE TEST KNITTER

This edition of the dress is a test knit version. Every stitch count has been calculated from the babies' measurements and the gauge, and checked against the others, but nobody has knitted from the pattern yet. You are the first. That means you may run into things I have not seen, and that is exactly why I need you.

WHAT I NEED FROM YOU

- Which size you knitted, and which yarn and needles you used.
- Your own gauge, measured on a washed swatch dried flat.
- The finished measurements of the garment after washing, in the form below.
- Anything unclear: a sentence you had to read three times, a stitch count that did not add up, a place where you had to guess.
- A photo of the finished garment, on the baby if you like.
- Tell me if the pattern reminds you of one you have seen before. Strawberry Dream is drawn for LME, and I want to know straight away if something still sits too close to something else.

MEASUREMENT FORM, FILL IN AFTER WASHING

Size knitted

My gauge, rounds per 10 cm

Chest after washing

Time taken, roughly

My gauge, stitches per 10 cm

Yarn and needles

Total length after washing

Yarn used, grams

HOW TO SEND IT IN

Send the form, your comments and any photos to <https://lmexplorers.com/teststrikk>. The deadline is given in the email the pattern came in.

Nothing is too small to mention. Whatever tripped you up will trip up the next knitter too, and it is far easier to fix now than later.

FINISHING AND AFTERCARE

CHECKLIST

- Weave in all ends flat and firmly on the wrong side. Do not cut them flush.
- Soak the work in lukewarm water with wool detergent. Do not rub or wring.
- Press the water out in a towel and dry the garment flat to the given measurements.
- Check all buttons, ties, edges and loose ends before the garment is worn.
- Measure the garment after washing and write the numbers in the form on the previous page.

SAFETY

Buttons and ties on baby garments must always be checked before use, and the garment worn only under supervision. Sew buttons on with strong thread and go over them again after every wash. On a premature baby the garment sits right against the skin, so feel that no seam or knot presses hard.

Happy knitting!

STRAWBERRY DREAM

THE WHOLE COLLECTION

- Strawberry Dream dress, sleeveless with a leaf yoke and a flared skirt.
- Strawberry Dream romper with skirt, with a nappy panel and buttons at the crotch.
- Strawberry Dream jumper and skirt, a two-piece set with an elasticated waist.
- Strawberry Dream mittens, thumbless, with a connecting cord.
- Strawberry Dream booties, with a folded rib cuff and ties at the ankle.

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